

The Picture Frames of Stanford White (1853 - 1906) William Adair, Gold Leaf Studios, Washington DC

Artists such as Thomas Wilmer Dewing, Augustus St. Gaudens and Abbot Thayer had a preference for the classically styled frames designed by Stanford White. The prestigious architectural firm of McKim, Meade and White was a staunch champion of the Renaissance Revival style. Not only did they receive many important commissions (including re-decoration of The White House), but they also founded the American Academy in Rome, an organization dedicated to the study of Classical ideals. The revival of these aesthetics held sacred during the Renaissance, Ancient Rome and Greece, were openly pursued by White and his colleagues. The picture frames he designed were carefully conceived to blend into the environment created by the architecture. The interiors possessed classical ornamentation of elaborate cornices and rich detail. As a result, White's frames were a logical choice for artists aspiring to similar ideals. Some of the patterns were inspired by the tabernacle style used by Piero della Francesca during the Renaissance (Fig. 1). The primary characteristic of the tabernacle style is an entablature supported by two pilasters flanking the perimeter of the painting. Other patterns he created resemble a "Whistlerian" profile, but instead of simple fluted reeds, White designed a variety of patterns with a Greek wave design, chevrons, twisted rope and ribbon, all combined into one flat profile (Fig. 2). Although White produced many designs (Fig. 3), the most innovative and distinctive pattern was the grille frame that resembles a gilded lattice or lace, suspended one inch over a brightly gilded panel. As a result of the panel's reflection from below, it produces a dazzling effect with only small amounts of available light. An optical illusion is produced that makes it appear that light is emanating from within the frame. This "halo" is particularly effective when combined with the luminescent quality of Dewing's paintings (Fig. 4). It may be for these reasons that Dewing preferred this style for many of his paintings. Unfortunately, these frames are extremely fragile and they are often found in a broken and deteriorated condition as a result of normal wear and tear for almost a century. Originally, these frames were well-constructed and the method used in gilding followed traditional techniques that are passed down from master craftsmen to apprentice among the gilding shops of Europe. There are several variations in manufacturing the grille pattern of these frames. One method consists of a wire mesh covered with a thick gesso (pastiglia) built up and dripped onto the thin metal wire to form an ornamental shape (Fig. 5). As this method must have been laborious, another type of grille appears that is made from "compo"* reinforced with a paper backing (Fig. 6). This latter type is the subject of the following conservation and fabrication discussion.

Brief Summary of the Conservation of Thomas Dewing Frame for "The Lute Player" (1905); Freer Gallery of Art, Smithsonian Institution; Washington, D.C. This Stanford White frame had been damaged from impact during shipping and handling. As a result, the grille was broken and pieces were missing in numerous areas which required treatment. Another problem was that the original surface had been covered with a bronze or "radiator paint" as a feeble attempt to refurbish the gold. In order to bring the frame back to its original condition, the bronze paint was removed using chemicals, to reveal traces of the original gilding. Prior to this stripping process, the grille was lifted from the frame by carefully removing the small brads originally used to affix it to the panel. By taking an impression with a rubber mold and pressing compo into the mold, the broken areas